doctrines of what we recognise today as Hindu *dharma* were first established (it is said, by the sage Yajnavalkya) in around 3000 BCE (many scholars dispute the historicity of this date, suggesting instead dates a millennia and a half later, 1500 BCE). They were reified in the four Vedas, composed roughly between 1700 and 500 BCE, laying down many of the mantras and benedictions, rituals and ceremonies of the faith, together with commentaries on these. The faith was then replenished by Veda Vyasa (the sage who is said to have codified the Vedas and is credited as the 'author' of the *Mahabharata*).

But despite the richness of the epics such as the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*, the religion of the later Vedas became excessively ritualistic and rigidly hierarchical. Other ideas and practices needed to be accommodated. Around 150 BCE, some centuries after Vyasa, Patanjali, a notable scholar of the Sankhya School of Hindu philosophy, compiled the *Yoga Sutras*, a classic text on yoga theory and practice, which laid the foundations of classical yoga. Patanjali's sutras lay down an eight-fold path, *ashtanga* yoga, which involves a rigorous set of physical, psychological and moral pursuits, following the strictest discipline, which, if progressively followed under the guidance of a suitable teacher, would lead the practitioner to ultimate self-realisation and pure consciousness. Then the *Upanishad*s emerged, throwing the light of sophisticated (and sometimes abstruse) philosophical enquiry on the faith. Building on the sacred Vedas, these were all foundational texts of Hinduism. The *Purana*s were composed, and their stories helped integrate the Vedic religion with the folk religions of India, absorbing them in a shared ethic.

Subsequently, Hinduism became paralysed by its own inflexible practices of orthodoxy, ritualism and formality, and the rise of mutually antagonistic sects locked in interminable conflict. Inevitably, reformers arose to challenge it, notably the ascetic Mahavira Jaina (c. 599 BCE–527 BCE) and the other-worldly Gautama Buddha (c. 563 BCE–483 BCE), whose followers branched out into new religions distinct from the Mimamsa Brahminism practised by mainstream Hindus. Both new faiths flourished for several centuries, as Hinduism descended into esoteric disputes over Sankhya dualism and Charvaka materialism. It was then, in